

System($3X \pm 1$)/4 Framework for the Collatz ($3x+1$) Problem

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Abstract

In order to gain deeper insight into the Collatz ($3x+1$) Problem, we design a framework based on System($3X \pm 1$)/4 defined similar to the Collatz ($3x+1$) system, with slightly modified operations. On similar lines, we define the CTUHSK($3x+1$)/4 system, and show that to be exactly the same as the Collatz ($3x+1$) system. The convergence of System($3X \pm 1$)/4 to its trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow (2) \Leftarrow 4)\}$ is established using the persistent local characteristic property of ‘odd-to-odd monotonicity’ in its defining function. We also present a meticulously designed reversible (invertible) transformation (reduction); between System($3X \pm 1$)/4 and the CTUHSK($3x+1$)/4 system; based on pruning-&-joining operations on the system arborescence; which does not affect the binary(inward)arborescence structure as well as the convergence characteristics of either of these systems. This establishes the convergence of the CTUHSK($3x+1$)/4 system to its trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow 2 \Leftarrow 4)\}$.

This paper also presents Halemane-Conjecture associated with the Collatz sequence, that the upper bound on the number of odd $(3x+1)$ operations required to reach the trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow 2 \Leftarrow 4)\}$ starting from any given positive integer and moving along the Collatz sequence, is the given number itself; the triad $\{(31 \Leftarrow 41 \Leftarrow 27)\}$ being an exceptional limiting case.

Keywords: System $(3X \pm 1)/4$; CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system;

Halemane's Conjecture on the Collatz $(3x+1)$ system;

Collatz-Thwaites-Ulam-Hasse-Syracuse-Kakutani (CTUHSK) Sequence;

Collatz-Thwaites-Ulam-Hasse-Syracuse-Kakutani (CTUHSK) Conjecture;

binary(inward)arborescence;

AMS MSC Mathematics Subject Classification: 11B83; 11Y55; 40A99; 93A99.

1. Introduction

The Collatz-Thwaites-Ulam-Hasse-Syracuse-Kakutani (CTUHSK) Conjecture, simply referred to as the *Collatz Conjecture* [§1] states that the Collatz $(3x+1)$ Sequence, also referred to as the Collatz Sequence, converges to the trivial-cycle, that is, $\{(1 \Leftarrow 2 \Leftarrow 4)\}$, starting from any positive integer.

Lagarias [§2]&[§3] gives an exhaustive annotated bibliography, whereas Lagarias [§4]&[§5] gives an elaborate overview of the Collatz Problem, also referred to as the “ $3x+1$ problem”, referring to it as “The Ultimate Challenge”. Guy [§6] has been somewhat pessimistic in advising researchers “Don’t Try to Solve These Problems”. Lagarias [§4]&[§5] refers to the statement by the most revered Mathematician and Number Theory Expert Paul Erdos, who said that - "Mathematics is not yet ready for such problems" - about the Collatz Conjecture. The Collatz ($3x+1$) Sequence is indeed a highly complex chaotic system, although defined or generated with one of the simplest deterministic well-defined equations, that too, just two in number. We will not get into any more of the reported literature except the problem definition; but will simply focus on a rather shockingly simple approach toward a possible resolution of this amazingly notorious long-standing unresolved problem.

This paper presents System($3x\pm 1$)/4 that is defined on similar lines as the Collatz ($3x+1$) system with slightly modified operations. Also, on similar lines, the CTUHSK($3x+1$)/4 system is defined and is shown to be exactly the same as the Collatz ($3x+1$) system. The System($3X\pm 1$)/4 is shown to converge to its trivial-cycle $\{(1\Leftarrow(2)\Leftarrow 4)\}$; using the local ‘odd-to-odd monotonicity’ property of the defining function. A meticulously designed reversible (invertible) transformation (reduction); between System($3X\pm 1$)/4 and the CTUHSK($3x+1$)/4 system; based on pruning-&-joining operations on the system arborescence; is shown not to affect the binary(inward)arborescence structure as well as the convergence characteristics; of either of these systems. It turns out that this establishes the convergence of the CTUHSK($3x+1$)/4 system to its trivial-cycle $\{(1\Leftarrow 2\Leftarrow 4)\}$.

2. System(3X±1)/4

System(3X±1)/4 H is defined on the set of positive integers, through its immediate-successor function $S(x) := H(x)$ as follows:

For any given positive integer $x > 1$;
 if & when $x=1$ stop; (trivial-cycle detected);
 elseIf $x \equiv 0 \pmod{4}$ then, $S(x) := H(x) := (x/4)$;
 elseIf $x \equiv 2 \pmod{4}$ then, $S(x) := H(x) := (x/2)$;
 elseIf $\{x \equiv 1 \pmod{4}\}$ then, $S(x) := H(x) := (3x+1)$;
 elseIf $\{x \equiv 3 \pmod{4}\}$ then, $S(x) := H(x) := (3x-1)$; [Eqn.1]

Table-1 gives the 4x4 state transition matrix $H(x,y)$ for System(3X±1)/4. Note that $[c]_b$ represents the modular (modulo-b) residue class c that a given number belongs to.

$H(x,y)$	$[0]_4$	$[2]_4$	$[1]_4$	$[3]_4$
$[0]_4$	0	1	1	1
$[2]_4$	0	0	1	1
$[1]_4$	1	0	0	0
$[3]_4$	1	0	0	0
Table-1: System(3X±1)/4				

Observe that as per the definition of System(3X±1)/4, for every positive integer x there is a single unique immediate-successor. Also note that as per the definition

of System(3X±1)/4, for any given positive integer, there exists an *immediate-even-predecessor* that is a positive even number, as a default. Additionally, for any given positive even number $x \in \{[2]_6, [4]_6\}$ of the form $(12m \pm 4)$; there exists an *immediate-odd-predecessor* that is a positive odd number.

This characteristic property results in a binary(inward)arborescence structure with the trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow (2) \Leftarrow 4)\}$ as a root and every odd multiple of 3 being an odd-leaf node with all its predecessors being only positive even numbers.

Table-2 gives the expanded 12x12 state transition matrix $H(x,y)$ for System(3X±1)/4, that explicitly captures and represents the above-mentioned characteristic property.

H(x,y)	[0] ₁₂	[4] ₁₂	[8] ₁₂	[2] ₁₂	[6] ₁₂	[10] ₁₂	[1] ₁₂	[5] ₁₂	[9] ₁₂	[3] ₁₂	[7] ₁₂	[11] ₁₂
[0] ₁₂	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
[4] ₁₂	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
[8] ₁₂	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
[2] ₁₂	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1
[6] ₁₂	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1
[10] ₁₂	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1
[1] ₁₂	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
[5] ₁₂	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
[9] ₁₂	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
[3] ₁₂	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
[7] ₁₂	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
[11] ₁₂	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Table-2: System(3X±1)/4 - 12x12 State Transition Matrix												

Also note that a positive even number $x \in \{[0]_{12}\} \vee \{[2]_{12}\} \vee \{[6]_{12}\} \vee \{[10]_{12}\}$ cannot have any *immediate-odd-predecessor*, and such nodes are called inactive-nodes in the system.

3. Observations on the Structure of System(3X±1)/4 H

The binary(inward)arborescence structure of the System(3X±1)/4 H has the following structure:

- (0) every node has exactly one immediate-successor.
- (1) every node has exactly one immediate-even-predecessor.
- (2) every even node $x \in \{[4]_{12}; [8]_{12}\}$ has exactly one immediate-odd-predecessor.
- (3) only an even node $x \in \{[4]_{12}; [8]_{12}\}$ has exactly one immediate-odd-predecessor; such nodes are called active-nodes.
- (4) no even node $x \in \{[0]_{12}; [2]_{12}; [6]_{12}; [10]_{12}\}$ has any immediate-odd-predecessor; such nodes are called inactive-nodes.
- (5) every odd-node $x \in [3]_6 := \{[3]_{12}; [9]_{12}\}$;
that is, x being an odd-multiple-of-3; is an odd-leaf-node;
none of its even predecessors can have any immediate-odd-predecessor.

4. Convergence of System(3X±1)/4

Note that every application of the $(3.x \pm 1)$ operation produces an immediate resultant positive even numbers $x \in \{[0]_4\}$; and therefore every $(3.x \pm 1)$ operation *must necessarily be followed by at least one* application of the $(x/4)$ operation; and may even be followed by further repetitions of it; leading to an *immediate decrease*

in the numerical value of the operand. Therefore, the resulting odd-to-odd sequence is a “*monotonically strictly decreasing odd-to-odd sequence*” – a characteristic property that we refer to as, a persistent local ‘odd-to-odd monotonicity’. This immediately establishes our assertion, that –

ASSERTION-1:

The System(3X±1)/4 converges to its trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow (2) \Leftarrow 4)\}$; starting with any positive integer.

This convergence property implies our assertion, that –

ASSERTION-2:

The system arborescence; representing the transitive-closure of the subset $\{1,5,3\}$; that is, $[\{1,5,3\}H+]$; under the inverse mapping of System(3X±1)/4; covers the entire set of positive integers.

5. Collatz (3x+1) system re-written as CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system

The Collatz(3x+1)/2System can be defined by its immediate-successor function S(x) for the (classical/canonical) Collatz (3x+1) system that can be written as –

For any given positive integer $x > 1$;
 if & when $x=1$ stop; (trivial-cycle detected);
 elseIf $x \equiv 0 \pmod{2}$ then, $S(x) := (x/2)$;
 elseIf $\{x \equiv 1 \pmod{2}\}$ then, $S(x) := (3x+1)$; [Eqn.2]

Observe that as per [Eqn.2]; for every positive integer x there exists a single unique immediate-successor.

Also note that the immediate-successor of any positive odd number of the form $(4m+1)$ in the Collatz sequence is a positive even number of the form $(12m+4)$; that is, a number $x \in \{[0]_4\}$ that is always divisible by 4 *at least once*, and therefore the combined operation can be denoted by a single $((3x+1)/4)$ operation; which leads to a clear decrease in the numerical value for the resultant odd number.

6. Critical-Issue, Critical-(Decision)-Node, Detour-Link, Detour-Node

The immediate-successor of any positive odd number of the form $(4m-1)$ in the Collatz sequence is a positive even number of the form $(12m-2)$; that is, a number $x \in \{[2]_4\}$ that is always divisible by 2 *exactly once* only. The combined operation can be denoted by a single $((3x+1)/2)$ operation, with its immediate resultant being a positive odd number of the form $(6m-1)$; with an increase in the numerical value of the operand. We designate this specific step $\{(12m-2) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\}$ in the Collatz sequence as a critical *detour-link*; because it is indeed the very source for the possible ambiguity (*critical-issue*) regarding the convergence of the Collatz sequence. The initial-node $(4m-1)$ of a detour-link is its *critical-(decision)-node*; and its terminal-node $(12m-2)$ is a *detour-node*. This *critical-issue* will be addressed appropriately in this paper.

As a first step, the Collatz $(3x+1)$ system originally defined by [Eqn.2] can now be re-written as an equivalent CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system; with a special single application of a $(x/2)$ operation in such specific cases whenever the operand is a positive even number of the form $(12m-2)$ arising as the immediate resultant of the application of the $(3x+1)$ operation on a positive odd number of the form $(4m-1)$.

Therefore, the Collatz $(3x+1)$ system is re-written & renamed as the CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system; that is -

Start with any given positive integer $x > 1$;

if & when $x=1$ stop; else continue;

elseIf $x \equiv 0 \pmod{4}$ then, $S(x) := C(x) := (x/4)$;

elseIf $x \equiv 2 \pmod{4}$ then, $S(x) := C(x) := (x/2)$;

elseIf $\{(x \equiv 1 \pmod{4}) \vee (x \equiv 3 \pmod{4})\}$ then, $S(x) := C(x) := (3x+1)$; [Eqn.3]

ASSERTION-3:

The CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system C is exactly identical to the Collatz $(3x+1)$ system; by its very definition.

Table-3 gives the 4x4 state transition matrix $C(x,y)$ for CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system.

$C(x,y)$	$[0]_4$	$[2]_4$	$[1]_4$	$[3]_4$
$[0]_4$	0	1	1	1
$[2]_4$	0	0	1	1
$[1]_4$	1	0	0	0
$[3]_4$	0	1	0	0
Table-3: CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system				

Observe that as per the definition of Collatz $(3x+1)$ system or its exact equivalent, the CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system, for every positive integer x there is a single unique immediate-even-predecessor, as a default. Additionally, for any given positive even number $x \in \{[4]_{12}\} \vee \{[10]_{12}\}$ of the form $\{(12m+4) \vee (12m-2)\}$ there exists an

immediate-odd-predecessor that is a positive odd number. This characteristic property results in a binary(inward)arborescence structure with its trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow 2 \Leftarrow 4)\}$ as a root and every odd multiple of 3 being an odd-leaf node. The system arborescence represents the transitive-closure of the subset $\{1,5,3\}$; that is, $\{1,5,3\}C^+\}$; under the inverse mapping of CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system. We will show that this is exactly the same as $\{1,5,3\}H^+\}$ which is exactly the entire set of positive integers.

Table-4 gives the expanded 12x12 state transition matrix $C(x,y)$ for CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system, that explicitly captures and represents the above-mentioned characteristic property.

$C(x,y)$	$[0]_{12}$	$[4]_{12}$	$[8]_{12}$	$[2]_{12}$	$[6]_{12}$	$[10]_{12}$	$[1]_{12}$	$[5]_{12}$	$[9]_{12}$	$[3]_{12}$	$[7]_{12}$	$[11]_{12}$
$[0]_{12}$	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
$[4]_{12}$	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
$[8]_{12}$	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
$[2]_{12}$	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1
$[6]_{12}$	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1
$[10]_{12}$	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1
$[1]_{12}$	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
$[5]_{12}$	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
$[9]_{12}$	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
$[3]_{12}$	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0
$[7]_{12}$	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0
$[11]_{12}$	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0
Table-4: CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system 12x12 State Transition Matrix												

Also note that a positive even number $x \in \{[0]_{12}\} \vee \{[2]_{12}\} \vee \{[6]_{12}\} \vee \{[8]_{12}\}$ cannot have any *immediate-odd-predecessor*, and such nodes are called inactive-nodes in the system.

Note that the highlighted entries in Table-3 and Table-4 indicate the differences in comparison with the corresponding entries in System(3X±1)/4 presented in Table-1 and Table-2.

7. Observations on the Structure of CTUHSK(3X±1)/4 system C

The binary(inward)arborescence structure of the CTUHSK(3X±1)/4 system C has the following structure:

- (0) every node has exactly one immediate-successor.
- (1) every node has exactly one immediate-even-predecessor.
- (2) every even node $x \in \{[4]_{12}; [10]_{12}\}$ has exactly one immediate-odd-predecessor.
- (3) only an even node $x \in \{[4]_{12}; [10]_{12}\}$ has exactly one immediate-odd-predecessor; such nodes are called active-nodes.
- (4) no even node $x \in \{[0]_{12}; [2]_{12}; [6]_{12}; [8]_{12}\}$ has any immediate-odd-predecessor; such nodes are called inactive-nodes.
- (5) every odd-node $x \in [3]_6 := \{[3]_{12}; [9]_{12}\}$;
that is, x being an odd-multiple-of-3; is an odd-leaf-node;
none of its even predecessors can have any immediate-odd-predecessor.

8. CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system compared with System(3X±1)/4

Note that the difference between System(3X±1)/4 and CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system; as highlighted in the tabular representation of the system state transitions; corresponds to only the critical-(decision)-node (4m-1). Observe that in CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system the critical-(decision)-node (4m-1) is linked to the detour-node (12m-2) through the detour-link $\{(12m-2) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\}$; whereas in System(3X±1)/4, the critical-(decision)-node (4m-1) is linked to the node (12m-4) through the link $\{(12m-4) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\}$. We designate that node (12m-4) as the *shortcut-node* and that link $\{(12m-4) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\}$ as the *shortcut-link*.

Now we define (1) transformation (reduction) H2T2C from the System(3X±1)/4 H to the CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system C; and also (2) transformation (reduction) C2T2H from the CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system C to the System(3X±1)/4 H; passing through a sequence of intermediate transition systems T; using a sequence of pruning-&-joining operations on the system arborescence.

9. From System(3X±1)/4 to the CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system

Perform the following **pruning-&-joining operation** on the System(3X±1)/4, recursively/iteratively, to transform it into the CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system.

(1) **PRUNING OPERATION:** Disconnect the critical-decision-node (4m-1) from the shortcut-node (12m-4); by pruning the shortcut-link $\{(12m-4) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\}$ in System(3X±1)/4 arborescence H. This pruning operation yields a free-hanging

subtree, with the critical-decision-node $(4m-1)$ as its root; that is denoted by $(4m-1)H+ \subseteq H$; corresponding to a branch of the original arborescence H .

- (2) JOINING OPERATION: Connect this critical-decision-node $(4m-1)$ onto the detour-node $(12m-2)$; which is known to be an otherwise inactive-node in $\text{System}(3X\pm 1)/4$; by a joining operation; through a newly created detour-link $\{(12m-2)\Leftarrow(4m-1)\}$. Note that the detour-node $(12m-2)$ is intended to act as an even-predecessor of an odd node $(6m-1)$ in the prospective CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system C being generated.

Thus, the entire subtree $(4m-1)H+ \subseteq H$ that was pruned in pruning operation, now gets joined to the detour-node $(12m-2) \in (6m-1)T+$ as a new branch; where T is an intermediate transition-system; consisting of the newly generated detour-links $\{(12m-2)\Leftarrow(4m-1)\}$ meant to be belonging to system C that is being generated, along with the remaining links of system H .

The above-described pruning-&-joining operation can be performed iteratively; that is, by replacing every link of the form $\{(12m-4)\Leftarrow(4m-1)\}$ with a link of the form $\{(12m-2)\Leftarrow(4m-1)\}$; for $m \in \{1, 2, 3, \text{etc.}\}$; without necessarily considering any network-based recursive algorithm to process on the subtrees etc.; although a network-based algorithm may facilitate in a better conceptual understanding of the process involved in the pruning-&-joining operations therein.

ASSERTION-4:

The above-described transformation (reduction) $H2T2C$ does not affect the binary(inward)arborescence structure of the $\text{System}(3X\pm 1)/4$ H .

This is because, at every iteration, the pruned subtree $[(4m-1)H+] \subseteq H$ is joined onto an already existing and hitherto inactive detour-node $(12m-2) \in H$ of the $\text{System}(3X\pm 1)/4 H$; or of the intermediate transition system T .

ASSERTION-5:

The transitive-closure of the subset $\{1,5,3\}$; that is, $[\{1,5,3\}C+] \subseteq C$; under the inverse mapping of the resultant $\text{CTUHSK}(3x+1)/4$ system C ; is exactly the same as the transitive-closure of the subset $\{1,5,3\}$; that is, $[\{1,5,3\}H+] \subseteq H$; under the inverse mapping of the original $\text{System}(3X\pm 1)/4 H$.

This is because, the entire transformation process $H2T2C$; consisting of a sequence of pruning-&-joining operations; wherein every pruning-&-joining operation preserves the original set of nodes in H while only replacing the shortcut-links $\{(12m-4)\Leftarrow(4m-1)\} \in H$ by the detour-links $\{(12m-2)\Leftarrow(4m-1)\} \in C$.

10. From the $\text{CTUHSK}(3x+1)/4$ system to $\text{System}(3X\pm 1)/4$

A similar pruning-&-joining process can be described to transform $\text{CTUHSK}(3x+1)/4$ system to $\text{System}(3X\pm 1)/4$, that is, by replacing every detour-link of the form $\{(12m-2)\Leftarrow(4m-1)\}$ by the corresponding newly created shortcut-link of the form $\{(12m-4)\Leftarrow(4m-1)\}$; as described below:

(a) **PRUNING OPERATION:** Disconnect the critical-decision-node $(4m-1)$ from the detour-node $(12m-2)$; by pruning the detour-link $\{(12m-2)\Leftarrow(4m-1)\}$ in $\text{CTUHSK}(3x+1)/4$ system arborescence C . This pruning operation yields a free-hanging subtree, with the critical-decision-node $(4m-1)$ as its root; denoted by $(4m-1)C+ \subseteq C$; corresponding to a branch of the original arborescence C .

(b) **JOINING OPERATION:** Connect this critical-decision-node $(4m-1)$ onto the shortcut-node $(12m-4)$; which is known to be an otherwise inactive-node in CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system; by a joining operation; through a newly created shortcut-link $\{(12m-4) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\}$. Note that the shortcut-node $(12m-4)$ is intended to act as an even-predecessor of a node $(3m-1)$ in the prospective System $(3X \pm 1)/4$ H being generated.

Thus, the entire subtree $(4m-1)C+ \subseteq C$ that was pruned in pruning operation, now gets joined to the shortcut-node $(12m-4) \in (3m-1)T+$ as a new branch; where T is an intermediate transition-system; consisting of the newly generated shortcut-links $\{(12m-4) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\}$ meant to be belonging to system H that is being generated, along with the remaining links of system C.

The above-described pruning-&-joining operation can be performed iteratively; that is, by replacing every link of the form $\{(12m-2) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\}$ with a link of the form $\{(12m-4) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\}$; for $m \in \{1, 2, 3, \text{etc.}\}$; without necessarily considering any network-based recursive algorithm to process on the subtrees etc.; although a network-based algorithm may facilitate in a better conceptual understanding of the process involved in the pruning-&-joining operations therein.

ASSERTION-6:

The above-described transformation (reduction) C2T2H does not affect the binary(inward)arborescence structure of the CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system C.

This is because, at every iteration, the pruned subtree $[(4m-1)C+] \subseteq C$ is joined onto an already existing and hitherto inactive shortcut-node $(12m-4) \in C$ of the CTUHSK $(3x+1)/4$ system C; or of the intermediate transition system T.

ASSERTION-7:

The transitive-closure of the subset $\{1,5,3\}$; that is, $[\{1,5,3\}H+] \subseteq H$; under the inverse mapping of the resultant System(3X±1)/4 H; is exactly the same as the transitive-closure of the subset $\{1,5,3\}$; that is, $[\{1,5,3\}C+] \subseteq C$; under the inverse mapping of the original CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system C.

This is because, every iteration step in the entire transformation process C2T2H; consisting of a sequence of pruning-&-joining operations; preserves the original set of nodes in C while only replacing the detour-links $\{(12m-2) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\} \in C$ by the shortcut-links $\{(12m-4) \Leftarrow (4m-1)\} \in H$.

11. Convergence of the CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system

Assertion-1 establishes the convergence of the System(3X±1)/4 to its trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow (2) \Leftarrow 4)\}$. Also, the system structure is shown to be a binary(inward)arborescence with this trivial-cycle as the root and every odd multiple of 3 being an odd-leaf node. The transitive-closure of the subset $\{1,5,3\}$; that is, $[\{1,5,3\}H+]$; under the inverse mapping of System(3X±1)/4; is shown to be the entire set of positive integers in assertion-2. Assertion-3 establishes that the CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system is exactly identical to the Collatz (3x+1) System. Assertions-4&6 together establish that the above-described pruning-&-joining process; while providing a transformation (reduction) mechanism between the System(3X±1)/4 and the CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system; does not affect the binary(inward)arborescence structure of either of these systems. Assertions5&7 together establish that the transitive-closure of the subset $\{1,5,3\}$; under the inverse

mapping of one system as represented by its binary(inward)arborescence; is exactly the same as that obtained for the other system.

These assertions together provide a definitive proof for the convergence of the Collatz (3x+1) System to its trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow 2 \Leftarrow 4)\}$.

Note that, the above transformation process from the System(3X±1)/4 to the CTUHSK(3x+1)/4System also guarantees (through a domain-exhaustion argument) the non-existence of either open chains/loops or open (infinite) threads or any other extraneous elements in the Collatz system. Also, every pruning-&-joining operation can be considered to be analogous to shifting from a shortcut sub-route to a detour sub-route or from a detour sub-route to a shortcut sub-route; wherein the shifting decision itself being taken at every critical-(decision)-node.

12. Summary

System(3X±1)/4 has been defined, similar to the Collatz (3x+1) system; with slightly modified operations. We have also defined the CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system, and shown that to be exactly the same as the Collatz (3x+1) system. The global convergence of System(3X±1)/4 to its trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow (2) \Leftarrow 4)\}$ is established using the persistent local 'odd-to-odd monotonicity' property of the defining function. A reversible (invertible) transformation between System(3X±1)/4 and CTUHSK(3x+1)/4 system has been designed, based on a process consisting of pruning-&-joining operations performed recursively/iteratively on the binary(inward)arborescence structure of the system. This pruning-&-joining operation does not affect the binary(inward)arborescence structure as well as the

convergence characteristics of either of these systems, because the pruned subtree is joined onto an already existing inactive-node of the system arborescence.

Halemane-Conjecture on the Collatz $(3x+1)$ sequence states that the maximum limit on number of odd $(3x+1)$ operations required to reach the trivial-cycle $\{(1 \Leftarrow 2 \Leftarrow 4)\}$; starting from any given positive integer and moving along the Collatz sequence; is the given number itself; with the triad $\{(31 \Leftarrow 41 \Leftarrow 27)\}$ as an exceptional limiting case.

13. Recommended Reading

[§1]. Wikipedia Page – https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Collatz_conjecture

[§2]. Jeffrey C Lagarias;
“The $3x+1$ problem: An annotated bibliography (1963--1999)
(sorted by author)”;
<https://arxiv.org/abs/math/0309224>

[§3]. Jeffrey C Lagarias;
“The $3x+1$ Problem: An Annotated Bibliography, II (2000-2009)”;
<https://arxiv.org/abs/math/0608208>

[§4]. Jeffrey C Lagarias;
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<https://arxiv.org/abs/2111.02635>

- [§5]. Jeffrey C Lagarias;
“The Ultimate Challenge: The $3x+1$ Problem”;
American Mathematical Society; 2010.
- [§6]. Richard K Guy;
“Don’t Try to Solve These Problems”;
The American Mathematical Monthly: Vol. 90, No. 1, pp. 35-41; 1983.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/00029890.1983.11971148>

14. A Confession and An Assertion

I must necessarily confess that the *core idea behind this proof of the Collatz Conjecture is so stunningly and elusively simple*, that one may simply be taken aback in a profound wonder-struck jaw-drop-silence, possibly with an after-thought: "OMG, *how could it be that it never flashed on me any time earlier*"!

However, I assert that क्लिष्टविशयसरलीकरणमेव पाण्डित्यलक्षणम् | न तु सरलविषयसंकलिष्टीकरणम् || That is, *to make the complex simple is a mark of mastery; not to make the simple complex.*

15. Declaration Regarding Affiliation and Funding

I, Dr(Prof) Keshava Prasad Halemane, hereby declare that I am a Professor retired as on 2017JAN31 from National Institute of Technology Karnataka Surathkal India, and I am not affiliated to any institution or organization or corporation or any other agency or whatever. This research work has been conducted entirely by me on my own as an Independent Researcher, and that I have not received any funding from any source other than my own savings, and I do not have any

obligations or encumbrances of any kind, neither financial nor legal nor of any other kind, regarding the contents of the manuscript - of which I am the original author and creator. Also, I hereby declare there is no conflict of interests.

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17. Dedication

To my ಅಜ್ಜ(ajja) Karinja Halemane Keshava Bhat & ಅಜ್ಜಿ(ajji) Thirumaleshwari, ಅಪ್ಪ(appa) Shama Bhat & ಅಮ್ಮ(amma) Thirumaleshwari, for their *teachings through love, that quality matters more than quantity*; to my wife Vijayalakshmi for her *ever consistent love & support*; to my daughter [Sriwidya.Bharati](#) and my twin sons [Sriwidya.Ramana](#) & [Sriwidya.Prawina](#) for their *love & affection*.